uncomfortable at times, he would refrain from sending me on sorties to unknown, isolated locations in the combat zone against my will. Little did he know that he could refrain only until I was the only option left for him.

The flight commander, Wing Commander Srivastav, explained the schedule for the next morning as we were about to sit down for dinner in the dining hall of our detachment. There was a planned communication sortie the next morning and the flight commander, along with another pilot, had to ferry a passenger in his helicopter to a helipad in the forward area; I, along with another pilot in the second helicopter, was supposed to accompany him as his back-up. So it was going to be a simple sortie the next day. The third helicopter of our detachment was supposed to stay in Srinagar with the other pilots, in case any contingency mission came up. After the briefing was over, we sat for dinner.

It was in the middle of our meal that an airman came with a message for the flight commander that the chief operations officer (COO) wanted to speak to him urgently. For a while there was silence around the table, with everyone contemplating what emergency it could possibly be. Such messages always brought anxiety in those days. The flight commander came back and informed us that there was a slight change in the schedule for the next morning. But this change wasn't going to be altogether comforting, especially for me. A sortie had been planned for casualty evacuation from a helipad very close to the LoC in the Uri sector, the flight commander informed us.

'But it isn't as simple as it sounds,' he added.

'Why, Sir?' one of our fellow pilots asked. But only I had an idea what the flight commander was concerned about.

'It's the helipad,' he said as he stirred his daal.

'Too close to the LoC,' another pilot said, 'but we've been to helipads close to the LoC. We know the drill.'

'Have you been to this one?' the flight commander asked, still not eating the food on his plate.

'No, Sir,' came a swift reply.